



The Reading Ladder

Most parents are told what their child should read next. Almost nobody is told what goes *in between*. Here is the ladder I actually use, and it is built on format, not on a reading level number.

The one idea worth keeping: “The jump from Dog Man to Magic Tree House isn’t a Lexile problem. It’s a format problem.” What changes from rung to rung is not how hard the words are. It is how much of the story the child has to carry.

Three rungs, and what each one asks of your reader

- 1** Graphic novels, like Dog Man
The pictures carry the story. A child can follow the whole thing from the panels. That is not a weakness. It is what gets a kid in the door.
- 2** Bridge books, like Adventures of Charlotte & Henry
The words carry the story, with the pictures helping. Short lines, white space, an illustration in every chapter. This is the rung that teaches a reader to trust text.
- 3** Chapter books, like Magic Tree House
The reader carries everything. Prose paragraphs, no line breaks to give you a breath. A child who skipped rung two hits a wall here and usually stops quietly.

Books I put on those rungs

BUILDING TOWARD MAGIC TREE HOUSE

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| ☐ Adventures of Charlotte & Henry: The Mariana Trench
Andrew Signore | ☐ A to Z Mysteries
Ron Roy |
| ☐ Adventures of Charlotte & Henry: Mount Everest
Andrew Signore | ☐ Dragon Masters
Branches / Scholastic |

AT OR ABOVE MAGIC TREE HOUSE LEVEL

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| ☐ My Father’s Dragon
Ruth Stiles Gannett | ☐ The Boxcar Children
Gertrude Chandler Warner |
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IF YOUR CHILD IS STUCK

Do not push them up a rung. Go find the one below and let them finish it. “Find the right bridge book first. Let them finish something.” The feeling of closing a book and wanting the next one is the thing you are actually after.

The full list, with why: BraveHeartsPublishing.com/blog/books-like-magic-tree-house/

The roadmap, rung by rung: BraveHeartsPublishing.com/blog/dog-man-to-magic-tree-house-reading-roadmap/